the foothills. The timing of their arrival in Tawang and Dirang Dzong in November was significant, as was the route taken by the troops. While one detachment came down the Khenzemane-Nyamjang Chu axis and entered Tawang, another followed the initial route taken by Morshead and Bailey, crossed Tse-la and arrived directly at Dirang Dzong after crossing Poshing-la.

Through the winter of 1942-43, the Tibetan troops encamped in both the Tawang and Kameng regions. During this period, the Tibetans conducted detailed surveys of the various alternate tracks that existed, especially yak trails that could be used to bypass Se-la if necessary. Further south, Bomdila and the tracks around Manda-la were also studied. The Tibetan troops established a camp near Bhalukpong for a while but were then withdrawn from the region by Lhasa.

British officers in Delhi handling the two northern countries felt that the developments in China would inevitably have an effect on Tibet. They were worried that inaction on the part of the British to the Tibetan ingress beyond Tawang might lead to further such incidents. Accordingly, during the next two years, the Assam Rifles set up permanent posts at Karbo, Riga, Pangin and Pasighat in the Siang River Valley, and also at Walong, Changwinti, Hayuliang and Denning in the Lohit River Valley. Even though maintaining these posts, especially during wartime, was a logistical nightmare, it was believed that the presence of Assam Rifles troops in the vicinity would act as a deterrent to any further Tibetan thrust. As the pressure began to ease in the east after the defeat of the Japanese at Kohima, aircraft belonging to the Royal Indian Air Force and the Royal Air Force began to undertake airdrop sorties. This reduced the administrative pressure on the Assam Rifles considerably.

While the Union Jack still fluttered over India, there would be a final twist in the tale. In April 1945, the Tibetan government presented to the British Mission in Lhasa a strongly worded protest that had been passed by the Tibetan National Assembly against British-Indian activities in the tribal areas south of the McMahon Line. Using flowery similes, the Tibetans in their letter talked of the ‘big insect’ eating up the ‘smaller insect’ which would cause ‘the bad name of the British Government’ to ‘spread like the wind’.

This letter caused a major flutter in London, New Delhi, Shillong and Gangtok for it looked like the Tibetans were questioning the 1914 Simla